

SPORTSPICS / IPL

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Josh Hazlewood overcame an injury hiatus to emerge as the unlikely hero in Royal Challengers Bengaluru's (RCB) charge to a maiden Indian Premier League (IPL) title. The 34-year-old finished as RCB's leading wicket-taker, claiming 22 wickets from 12 innings. Head coach Andy Flower underlined the team management's focus on assembling a potent bowling unit, and Hazlewood proved to be its linchpin, justifying the faith placed in him despite missing the previous season.

Renowned for his relentless hard-length accuracy in Test cricket, Hazlewood stuck to the same formula in the IPL. He bowled back-of-length 106 times this season — only four pacers targeted the zone more frequently, but none took more wickets (8) off it.

In a format where yorkers are often viewed as the go-to death-over weapon, Hazlewood relied instead on precision length bowling. He bowled just 14 yorkers all season, yet picked up seven wickets and conceded at 10.69 runs per over between overs 16 and 20. His biggest impact, though, came in the PowerPlay. Half of his 264 deliveries this season came in the first six overs, where he claimed 10 wickets at a miserly economy rate of 7.27. While Khaleel Ahmed and Trent Boult also picked 10 wickets in this phase, neither matched Hazlewood's economy rate nor his average (15.80).

His early breakthroughs proved decisive in the Playoffs. Against Punjab Kings, he dismissed Shreyas Iyer and Josh Inglis inside the PowerPlay, triggering a batting collapse. In the final, he removed Priyansh Arya in the fifth over, snapping a threatening opening stand. RCB sorely missed his control late in the league stage when he was sidelined with a shoulder injury. That the side conceded 200-plus in three straight games without Hazlewood is telling of his ability to put shackles on batters.

For much of their 18-year IPL journey, RCB has banked on star batters to win matches. Hazlewood's standout season served as a timely reminder that bowlers, too, can shape titles — even in a batter-driven format.

MATCHES

12

Wickets

22

Economy

8.77

Average

17.54

Best

4/33

**CALM
CHAOS**

ORANGE CAP WINNER
Sai Sudharsan

PURPLE CAP WINNER
Prasidh Krishna

MOST VALUABLE PLAYER
Suryakumar Yadav